

7.1 Communication

Communication is simply an act of transferring information from one place, person or group to another. Every communication involves (at least) one sender, a message and a recipient. This may sound simple, but communication is actually a very complex subject. The transmission of the message from sender to recipient can be affected by a huge range of factors. These include our emotions, the cultural situation, the medium used to communicate, and even our location.

7.1.1 Categories of Communication

There are various ways in which we communicate. The different categories of communication include:

- **Spoken or Verbal Communication**, which includes face-to-face, telephone, radio or television and other media.
- **Non-Verbal Communication**, covering body language, gestures, how we dress or act, where we stand, and even our scent. There are many subtle ways that we communicate (perhaps even unintentionally) with others. For example, the tone of voice can give clues to mood or emotional state, whilst hand signals or gestures can add to a spoken message.
- **Written Communication**, which includes letters, e-mails, social media, books, newspapers, magazines, the Internet and other media. Until recent times, a relatively small number of writers and publishers were very powerful when it came to communicating the written word. Today, we can all write and publish our ideas online, which has led to an explosion of information and communication possibilities.
- **Visualizations**: graphs and charts, maps, logos and other visualizations can all communicate messages.

7.1.2 Principles of Effective Communication

The following are the principles of effective communication:

- **Listening:** One of the most important aspects of effective communication is being a good listener.
- Non-Verbal Communication.
- Be clear and be concise.
- Be confident.
- Be empathetic.
- Always have an open mind.
- Convey respect.

7.1.3 Obstacles in Effective Communication

Barriers in communication can be categorized into four main types of constraints: Physical, psychological, organizational and semantic barriers. Physical barriers have nothing to do with the communicators themselves. Apart from this, there are also some cultural, language and gender barriers.

Besides physical and technical barriers, there are six barriers to effective communication:

Dissatisfaction or Disinterest with One's Job

If you are unhappy or have lost interest in your job, you are far less likely to communicate effectively. In other words, your heart isn't in it. This barrier, is perhaps the most difficult to overcome because it involves changing a mindset, and thus it typically doesn't change until the person leaves.

Inability to Listen to Others

Active listening is an important aspect of effective communication. You cannot engage with someone if you are not listening to them because you will tend to make assumptions about their needs based on your perceptions versus reality.

Lack of Transparency & Trust

It is extremely difficult to communicate anything when there is a lack of transparency and trust. For example, if your staff believes you are holding something back, they will be anxious, some will speculate, and as a result, it will be more difficult for them to process any attempt you make to communicate with them.

Communication Styles

Everyone has their own communication style. Some people are very direct while others prefer a more indirect approach. Some use detailed data, while others rely on generalities, and so forth. Occasionally, one person is so entrenched in their way of communicating, they find it difficult to communicate with others who rely on a different style. You might hear comments such as, “Mary never explains what she wants me to do, she’s never specific” or “Bill gets so caught up in the weeds, that I lose focus on the bigger picture.”

Conflicts in the Workplace

Conflict can happen for a variety of reasons and when it does, it becomes a barrier to effective communication. The nature of the conflict is not necessarily important, what is important is working to resolve the conflict. When conflict is not eradicated, it grows and then people begin to take sides, which further impedes effective communication.

Cultural Differences & Language

It is important to understand the cultural differences in communication. There can also be regional differences. For instance, a northerner might not like the term "y'all" or even understand the more comprehensive version, "all y'all".

7.1.4 Principles for Effective Team Communication

Principles of effective communication are:

1. Have an open-door policy
2. Use project management software
3. Be open to feedback
4. Be clear about individual task responsibility
5. Do fun stuff to boost morale

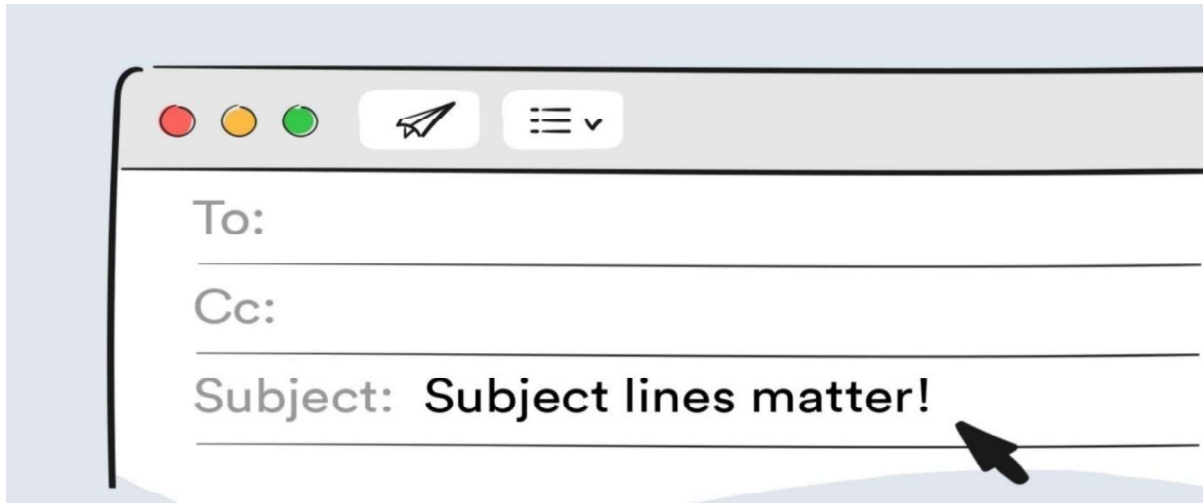
6. Give purpose to coffee breaks
7. Consider formal communications training
8. Decide what forms of communication work best
9. Identify group leaders
10. Understand diversity issues

7.2 Effective Email Writing

Email is a valuable tool but in the meantime, it creates some challenges for writers. Miscommunication can easily occur when people have different expectations about the messages that they send and receive. Email is used for many different purposes, including contacting friends, communicating with professors and supervisors, requesting information, and applying for jobs, internships, and scholarships. Depending on your purposes, the messages you send will differ in their formality, intended audience, and desired outcomes. The following are some important components of an email:

Subject Lines

Email subject lines are like newspaper headlines. They should convey the main point of your message or the idea that you want the reader to take away. Therefore, be as specific as possible. One-word subjects such as “Hi,” “Question,” or “FYI” are not informative and don’t give the reader an idea of how important your message is. If your message is time sensitive, you might want to include a date in your subject line, like “Meeting on Thurs, Dec 2”.



Note for teachers.

➤ Compose an example email in class.

Greetings and Sign-offs

Use some kind of greeting and some kind of sign-off. Don't just start with your text, and don't just stop at the end without a polite signature. If you don't know the person well, you may be confused about how to address them ("What do I call my TA/professor?") or how to sign off (Best? Sincerely?). Nonetheless, it is always better to make some kind of effort. When in doubt, address someone more formally to avoid offending them. Some common ways to address your reader are:

- Dear Professor Smith,
- Hello Ms. McMahon,
- Hi Mary Jane,

If you don't know the name of the person you are addressing, or if the email addresses a diverse group, try something generic, yet polite:

- To whom it may concern,
- Dear members of the selection committee,
- Hello everyone,

Your closing is extremely important because it lets the reader know who is contacting them. Always sign off with your name at the end of your message. If you don't know the reader well, you might also consider including your title and the organization you belong to; for example:

Mary Watkins
Senior Research Associate
Bain and Company
Joseph Smith
UNC-CH, Class of 2009

For your closing, something brief but friendly, or perhaps just your name, will do for most correspondence:

- Thank you,
- Best wishes,
- See you tomorrow,
- Regards,

For a very formal message, such as a job application, use the kind of closing that you might see in a business letter:

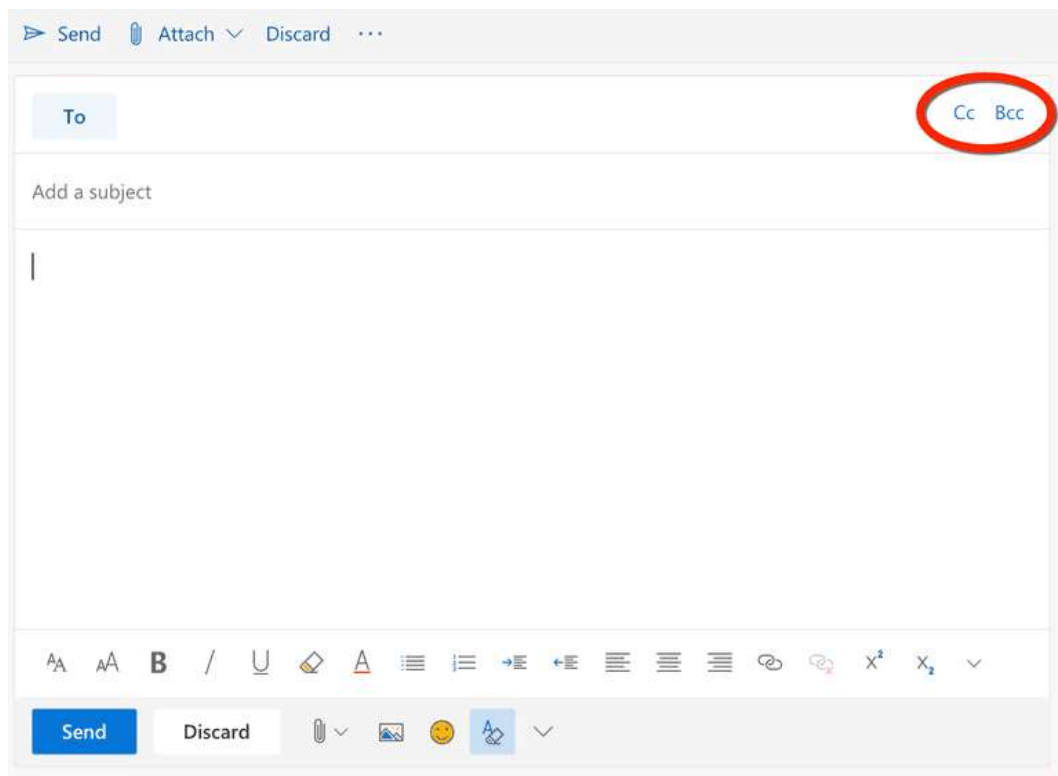
- Sincerely,
- Respectfully yours,

Cc: and Bcc: ('carbon copy' and 'blind carbon copy')

Copying individuals on an email is a good way to send your message to the main recipient while also sending someone else a copy at the same time. This can be useful if you want to convey the same exact message to more than one person. In professional settings, copying someone else on an email can help get things done, especially if the person receiving the copy is in a supervisory role. For example, copying your boss on an email to a non-responsive co-worker might prompt the co-worker to respond. Be aware, however, that when you send a message to more than one address using the Cc: field, both the original recipient and all the recipients of the carbon copies can see all the

addresses in the To: and Cc: fields. Each person who receives the message will be able to see the addresses of everyone else who received it.

Blind copying emails to a group of people can be useful when you don't want everyone on the list to have each other's addresses. The only recipient address that will be visible to all recipients is the one in the To: field. If you don't want any of the recipients to see the email addresses in the list, you can put your own address in the To: field and use Bcc: exclusively to address your message to others. However, do not assume that blind copying will always keep recipients from knowing who else was copied—someone who is blind copied may hit “reply all” and send a reply to everyone, revealing that they were included in the original message.



7.3 Role of Social Media in Marketing

Marketing is a tool to inform consumers about your products, who you are, and what you offer. Social media accomplishes all of these goals:

- You can use social media to define your brand identity and the products or services that you offer.
- Social media allows you to create relationships with people who might not know about your products and services or what your company represents.
- Social media can make you "real" to consumers. If you want people to follow you, don't just talk about the latest product news, but share your personality with them.
- You can use social media to associate yourself with peers that may be serving the same target market.

Advantages of Social Media

The business benefits of effective social media use include:

- **Brand awareness** - Compelling and relevant content will grab the attention of potential customers and increase brand visibility.
- **Brand reputation** - You can respond instantly to industry developments and be seen as 'thought leader' or expert in your field. This can improve how your business is seen by your audience.
- **Cost effective** - It can be much **cheaper** than traditional advertising and promotional activities. The costs of maintaining a social media presence are minimal. If you choose to invest in paid advertising, you can spend as much or as little as your budget allows.
- **Website traffic** - Social content can boost traffic to your website. This can lead to increased online conversions such as sales and leads.
- **Evaluation** - It is easy to measure how much website traffic you receive from social media. You can set up tracking to determine how many sales are generated by paid social advertising.
- **Customer interaction** - You can deliver improved customer service and respond effectively to feedback. Positive feedback is public and can be persuasive to other potential customers. Negative feedback highlights areas where you can improve.

- **Target audience** - Customers can find you through the social media platforms they use most. You can choose to maintain a presence on particular platforms that are in line with your target audience. For example, if you are targeting young people, you could reach them through Snapchat. If you are seeking business customers, LinkedIn may be the best channel.

Disadvantages of Social Media

Some of the disadvantages of using social media include:

- **Resources:** Resources are required to manage presence on social media i.e., responding to feedback and producing new content. This can include hiring and training staff, investing in paid advertising and paying for the costs of creating video or image content.
- **Ineffective use:** Social media can be used ineffectively. For example, using social media to push for sales without engaging with customers, or failing to respond to negative feedback - may damage your reputation.

Key Points

- Communication is simply the act of transferring information from one place, person or group to another.
- These barriers can be categorized into four main types of constraints to effective communication: Physical, psychological, organizational, as well as semantic barriers.
- Email subject lines are like newspaper headlines. They should convey the main point of your message or the idea that you want the reader to take away.
- Copying individuals on an email is a good way to send your message to the main recipient while also sending someone else a copy at the same time.
- Blind copying emails to a group of people can be useful when you don't want everyone on the list to have each other's addresses.
- Marketing is a tool we use to inform consumers about our products, who we are, and what we offer.

Exercise

Select the most appropriate option.

1. Which option hides other recipients from all recipients.
a. CC b. BCC c. Subject Line d. All of these
2. Communication barriers can be categorized into _____ types.
a. 5 b. 3 c. 4 d. Both a and b
3. The following quality of your business builds relationships.
a. Brand loyalty b. Customer Interaction c. Evaluation d. None of these
4. _____ contains the headlines of your email.
a. Attachment b. Subject line c. Text d. Both a and b
5. _____ is a face to face medium of communication.
a. Spoken b. Verbal c. Non verbal d. Both a and b

Answer the following question.

1. Define Communication Skills.
2. What are the different forms of communication?
3. What are the principles for an effective communication?
4. What are the common barriers in communication?
5. What are the main components of an email?
6. What communication skills are required in a team work?
7. Describe advantages and disadvantages of social media.